

Account-Shopping Checklist

Financially Sovereign Academy · Module 3: Banking Without Getting Robbed · Worksheet v0.1 · 2026-07-04

What this is. Banks make money on fees you may not see until they hit. This one page helps you ask the right questions before you open an account, and compare two options side by side. Fill it in by hand. Example amounts are examples only; use your own numbers.

1. Fees to ask about before opening

From Module 3: a “free” account can still cost you. Ask about each of these in writing.

- ☐ Overdraft fee: how much per charge, and how many per day? \$ _____
- ☐ Monthly maintenance fee, and how to waive it: \$ _____
- ☐ Out-of-network ATM fee: \$ _____
- ☐ Wire transfer fee (in and out): \$ _____
- ☐ Paper statement fee: \$ _____
- ☐ Minimum balance required to avoid fees: \$ _____

2. Red flags to watch for

Any one of these is a reason to slow down and read more.

- ☐ Overdraft is turned on by default without asking me
- ☐ Fees are hard to find or the staff cannot explain them
- ☐ Pressure to open extra products I did not ask about
- ☐ No free way to avoid the monthly fee
- ☐ Other: _____

3. Compare two accounts

Fill in real numbers from two banks or credit unions you are considering.

Feature	Account A: _____	Account B: _____
Monthly fee	\$ _____	\$ _____
How to waive monthly fee	_____	_____
Overdraft fee	\$ _____	\$ _____
Out-of-network ATM fee	\$ _____	\$ _____
Minimum balance	\$ _____	\$ _____
Free online / mobile access	[]	[]
Insured (FDIC or NCUA)	[]	[]

4. My non-negotiables

Circle what matters most to you, then pick the account that fits.

- Most important to me: low fees · easy waiver · nearby branch · good app · _____
- The account that fits best right now: _____

5. Pressure and trap reminder

From Module 3: the account that is easiest to open is not always the cheapest to keep. Sign-up bonuses can hide monthly costs.

- One fee I will double-check before I sign: _____
- One question I will ask a real person: _____

6. My next 7-day action

One small thing I will do in the next 7 days: _____

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